Proverbs: collection 3 -- an English prose translation

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Paragraph labels = ETCSL composite line ranges covered by each translation paragraph. "..." = untranslatable/lost text.

Segment A

1-3. [note: cf. 6.2.5: TIM 10/1 2, 1.8.1.1: ll. 25-28] To stand and to sit, to spur on the donkeys, to support (?) the prince: who has the breath for that?

4. You are peering out from the parapet like the prince's nurse.

5. Because you draw water, the swamp may drink. [note: 1 ms. has instead:] You draw water for pouring out, so that the swamp may drink water.

6. Unpleasant ..... plants grow towards [note: 1 ms. has instead:] rise up to a good field.

7-9. I will feed you even though you are an outcast (?). I will give you drink even though you are an outcast (?). You are still my son, even if your god has turned against you.

10-12. [note: cf. 6.1.16.b7] "I will go today" is what a herdsman says; "I will go tomorrow" is what a shepherd-boy says. "I will go" is "I will go", and the time passes.

13-14. [note: 1 ms. adds:] Wealth is exposed to the winds. The churned milk, although it isn't river mud, is diverted into cracks in the ground.

15-16. *(2 lines fragmentary)*

17-20. [note: cf. 6.1.26.a5, 6.2.1: Ni 4122 ll. 2-5] [note: 1 ms. adds:] To serve beer with unwashed hands, To spit without trampling upon it, to sneeze without covering it with dust, to kiss with the tongue at midday without providing shade, are abominations to Utu.

21-22. [note: cf. 6.1.01.153, 6.1.16.b4-5, 6.1.22: ll. 26-27, 6.1.23.7] A shepherd his penis, a gardener his hair. An unjust heir who does not support a wife, or who does not support a child, has no cause for celebration.

23-24. [note: cf. 6.1.16.b2] If you get rid of the shepherd, then his sheep will not return.

25-26. [note: cf. 6.1.16.b3] Because the clever shepherd became confused, his sheep did not return.

27. A shepherd-boy when weary cannot recognise his own mother.

28. While you still have light, grind the flour.

29. [note: cf. 6.1.05.3] The wild bull is taboo for the plough.

30-33. [note: cf. 6.1.22: ll. 216-217] To eat modestly doesn't kill a man, but to covet will murder you. To eat a little is to live splendidly. When you walk about, keep your feet on the ground!

34-35. As long as he is alive, he is his friend. When he is dead, he is his worst demon.

36-37. [note: cf. 6.1.16.d2] Friendship lasts for just one day [note: 1 ms. has instead:] three days but collegiality lasts forever.

38-39. Quarrelling occurs wherever there are colleagues [note: 1 ms. has instead:] one of the group is senior to the rest . Slander occurs even where there has been purification.

40-41. When travelling, a man does not tire of eating. He gathers in food all day long.

42. There are bitter tears in human flesh.

43-44. Not buying vegetables (?) [note: 1 ms. has instead:] Buying ..... , a promise (?) not fulfilled (?), handing over worthless money, not removing a mote from the eye.

45-46. A hand will stretch out towards an outstretched hand. A hand will open for an opened hand.

47-48. [note: cf. 6.1.22: ll. 284-286, 6.2.3: UET 6/2 265 ll. 2-3, 6.2.5: IM 62823 Seg. A ll. 7-8] He who has silver is happy; he who has grain feels comfortable; he who has livestock can sleep.

49-50. [note: cf. 6.2.5: YBC 4677 l. 11] Enlil, ..., my loincloth is [note: 1 ms. has instead:] is not gone (?).

51-52. [note: cf. 6.1.19.c1, 6.2.5: YBC 4677 ll. 8-10] What did Enlil make? Chaff! The lance struck. It went into the flesh.

53-54. [note: cf. 6.1.19.c2, 6.1.24.9] When the sun is setting outside so that you cannot even recognise the hand in front of you, go indoors!

55-56. King Išbi-Erra ..... with his hand ..... *(1 line fragmentary)*

57-58. *(2 lines fragmentary)* [note: 1 ms. has instead:] *(2 lines fragmentary)*

59-62. *(4 lines fragmentary)*

63-65. Enlil ..... *(2 lines fragmentary)*

66-72. [note: cf. 3.35, 6.1.09.b1, 6.1.11.18, 6.1.15.b8, 6.1.25.4, 6.2.1: Ni 4469 Seg. A ll. 9-12] Nanni cherished his old age. He built the temple ..... He built a wall around Nibru, but ..... He built E-ana, but after abandoning it, ... He captured Simurrum, but did not ..... its wall. He never saw mighty kingship. Thus Nanni was carried off to the nether world.

73-75. *(2 lines fragmentary)* like beer ..... in front of him .....

76. [note: cf. 6.1.07.100] He who says "I will live for today" is bound like a bull on a nose-rope.

77. Ur-Namma ..... large mirrors in Enlil's temple.

78-79. [note: cf. 3.31] Nanni cherished his old age: "I am what an old man should be."

80-81. [note: cf. 6.2.3: UET 6/2 325 ll. 3-5, 6.2.5: IM 62823 Seg. B ll. 11-12] The voluptuous slave girl says: "Let Iškur, ... god ..... king ..... split the fertile ground like a cucumber."

82-84. [note: cf. 6.1.21.c11-12] A slave girl is one who ..... the door. The slave girl from the palace offers advice (?) continually. The slave from the palace eats the ex-voto offering [note: perhaps an idiom] .

85-86. A slave girl carried her release money with her. ..... 30 minas.

87. [note: cf. 6.2.3: UET 6/2 335 l. 1] You grind with the pestle like a fearful slave girl.

88-91. The slave girl who neglected to fill the containers grumbled: "It does not fill (?) to the top; it does not fill (?) the middle."

92-93. [note: cf. 6.1.19.d9, 6.1.28.25] When the lady left the house and the slave girl entered from the street, away from her lady the slave girl sat at her own banquet.

94-95. [note: cf. 6.1.22: ll. 278-279, 6.2.1: Ni 9824 Seg. C ll. 1-2, 6.2.5: YBC 8713 l. 7] When there is a dispute at the mill, a slave girl reveals (?) what she has stolen.

96-98. He who sleeps with a slave girl ..... with a strong male ..... what the slave girl has stolen, what the lady ..... with a man -- one person does not reveal to another.

99. The joy of a daughter-in-law is anger.

100-101. [note: cf. 6.1.07.43, 6.2.1: Ni 9832 Seg. B ll. 6-7] To a slave girl who has not been purchased, the upper millstone ..... You are forever pushing like a millstone torn out of its joint.

102-103. Let me come in! Let me ..... it! Let me destroy it! .....

104. The just god ..... cut reeds (?) .....

105. Let me buy it! Let me ..... !

106. *(1 line fragmentary)*

107-108. *(2 lines missing)*

109-110. *(2 lines missing)*

111. *(1 line fragmentary)*

112. Like a ..... on a socle.

113. Like a suckling bull .....

114-115. [note: cf. 6.1.07.48, 6.1.11.5] As long as you live you should not increase evil by telling lies; for if you do, to succumb will be your lot.

116. The righteous ..... the wicked .....

117. ..... and I'm not a treasure chest or a .....

118. *(1 line unclear)*

119-120. [note: cf. 6.1.25.3] The lord [note: i.e. An (?)] cursed Unug, but so was he cursed by the lady of E-ana [note: i.e. Inana] .

121. [note: cf. 6.1.07.80] I am a loyal steward with strong arms.

122. Let the sides be separated; let me be the one who ..... the sides.

123. It is on account of being the boss that you bully me.

124-125. Because of his arrogance, may his head be bowed to his neck like a damp reed.

126-127. [note: cf. 6.1.17.b7] Weighing scales made with a net are a trap made for the feet; a man should not take a merchant for his friend.

128. [note: cf. 6.1.01.165, 6.1.17.b8, 6.1.22: ll. 194-196] You, merchant, how small you made the amount of silver! And how small you made the amount of oil and barley!

129-130. [note: cf. 6.1.22: l. 197] That which in the trade is considered a lump of lapis lazuli is for its owner a stone that .....

131. One cannot drag out the weak, one cannot hold back the strong.

132-133. [note: cf. 3.85] Let our odour be the smell of leeks -- let it not be the smell of turnips!

134-135. [note: cf. 6.1.11.22] He who insults is insulted. He who sneers is sneered at.

136-137. A lion caught in the trap in the storehouse becomes mine in this way: the owner simply removes the wood.

138-139. [note: cf. 6.1.11.19, 6.1.19.b6, 6.1.24.5] *(1 line unclear)* ..... its hands to the edge of the desert.

140. A lizard follows like a snake, like a .....

141. Like a ..... worker, keeping watch is not what is on his mind.

142-143. A tenant established the house, and ploughing established the field.

144. [note: cf. 6.1.07.17, 6.2.5: YBC 9912] “I am stretching my legs on your behalf,” says a man delivering sesame.

145-146. You invoke the oath of Iškur, who destroys the mountains, but ..... you cannot cross the river with a boat.

147-148. [note: cf. 6.2.3: UET 6/2 382 l. 3] Iškur splits the mountains, yet he does not split the waterskin.

149. ..... which I have found, its dates are from Dilmun.

150. A runaway slave girl only pretends to sleep.

151-152. The gazelle in the ..... desert feeds its young with milk.

153. Eyes of ..... are characteristic of the Akkadians (?).

154-155. [note: cf. 6.1.07.13] He moves like a lion against a louse, but when there is a job is to be done, he moves like a rat.

156-157. [note: cf. 6.1.22: l. 85] As the sun rises, decisions are made. By the time the sun is up, kingship is conferred.

158-159. [note: cf. 6.1.28.1] The battle-club would not find out your name -- it would just find your flesh.

160-161. [note: cf. 3.68] Our own odour is of pulled-up turnips -- sweet things are brought by strangers.

162-163. [note: cf. 6.1.26.b5-6] “Give me!” is what the king says. “Do well!” is what the cupbearer's son says.

164-167. What characterises the carpenter is the chisel. What characterises the reed weaver is the basket. What characterises the smith is the making of little ..... What characterises the singer are the sounds *ua* and *alala*.

168-169. [note: cf. 6.1.18.14, 6.1.24.7] He who tosses his head succeeds in crossing the river. ..... the Tigris ..... [note: 1 ms. has instead:] ..... negligent ..... [note: possibly belongs to a different proverb] .

170-171. [note: cf. 6.1.11.25] If the foreman does not know how to assign the work, his workers will not stop shaking their heads.

172. *(1 line fragmentary)*

173. Enlil's temple is a summation of accounts. The temple manager is its overseer.

174. [note: cf. 6.1.14.18] Enlil's temple is a gathering (?) of wages.

175. [note: cf. 6.2.4: VAT 21604 (+) 21605 Seg. B l. 3] Enlil's greatest punishment is hunger.

176-177. If one does not give the dog something, it will bark at every woman.

178-179. [note: cf. 6.1.05.93] She growls like a dog struck by a throw-stick [note: 1 ms. has instead:] ball (?) .

180. That which is made of evil threads grumbles.

181-182. “Just-let-me-say-a-word” walks like feet. Who can rival a garrulous man?

183-184. ..... floating on the river and ..... diminishes.

185. [note: cf. 3.101] You speak to me -- and I will speak to you!

186. He who ..... is the one who eats something.

187-188. [note: cf. 3.99] You speak with me and I speak with you.

189. Fools are the ribcages of heroes.

190. The fool is garrulous.

191-192. [note: cf. 6.1.07.73] The dog moves, the knife moves, but still my man does not move.

193-194. Where someone is lame, ... the emissary of Bau comes to their aid.

195-196. [note: cf. 6.1.28.26] Where there is no grain, this is a sign of vengeance turned towards a city. Where there are no reeds, it is the worst of all poverty.

197-199. Something offered is not offered. Something finished is not finished. Nothing changes.

199. A vagrant flays the skin of an opened hand.

200. The two of them are like one man.

201-202. Were he to find where I put my rubbish heap, he would say: “You shouldn't go there!”

203. [note: cf. 6.1.08.b7] Although it has never been there, the goat knows the wasteland.

204-205. [note: cf. 6.1.22: ll. 19-20, 6.1.28.28, 6.2.3: UET 6/2 311 ll. 4-5] With my mouth I cool the hot soup for you. I pick the bones from the fish for you.

206. [note: cf. 6.2.3: UET 6/2 311 l. 1] My mouth, every month I fill you, my mouth.

207. [note: cf. 6.2.3: UET 6/2 311 ll. 2-3] My tongue, like a runaway donkey, will not turn back.

208-211. All day long my food ration is kept away from me, my heart ....., but even a dog can satisfy its hunger. It's over for me, but should I be happy? My mother would not give me second helpings.

212-213. The ox standing in the fodder abandoned the calf to enter the pen.

214. [note: cf. 6.1.19.g1] You may lift it all together but you will put it down in pieces.

215-217. [note: cf. 6.1.26.a8] When a man comes forward as a witness, saying: “Let me tell you what I know about him”, but does not know the relevant information, it is an abomination to Suen.

218. Flies enter an open mouth.

219. Offerings create life.

220. Punishment is assigned for the swaggerer; he is afflicted with diseases.

221. Let him go down.

222-223. You should hold a kid in your right arm, and a bribe in your left arm.

224. [note: cf. 6.1.07.14] The manicurist is himself dressed in dirty rags.

225. [note: cf. 5.4.01: l. 98] He came, he stayed a while; he finished, he did not stay put.

226-227. He spoke ..... not ..... his mouth is full of lies. [note: 1 ms. has instead:] *(2 lines fragmentary)*

228-230. My fingernail that hurts is clutched in my embrace. My foot that hurts is in my sandal. But who will find my aching heart?

231. May Inana pour oil on my heart that aches.

232. The sail on the mast blocks the river.

233. May you find the response to an insult hurled at you in a dispute.

234-235. If it is too sweet for him, let him eat salt. If it is not too sweet for him, let him eat licorice.

236. Before the fire has gone out, write your exercise tablet!

237-238. Where .....? Solve .....!

239-241. ..... slave girl ..... ill ..... basket ..... myself ..... you sprinkle the dirt on the .....

242-243. [note: cf. 6.2.3: UET 6/2 255] A man's personal god is a shepherd who finds pasturage for the man. Let him lead him like sheep to the food they can eat.

244-246. As long as the boasters haven't departed, their mouths make me uneasy.

247-249. The heavens were destroyed, the earth was shaken. After the heavens were destroyed and the earth was shaken, the people were still standing there on their own.

250. The rigging is not ship-shape, and the stern is not seaworthy.

251. He who entered Elam -- his lips are sealed.

252. He who has to live in Elam -- his life is not good.

253-254. [note: cf. 6.1.07.95] Wheat and hulled barley was made to taste like honey. The nomad ate it and didn't recognise what was in it.

255. He who keeps fleeing, flees from his own past.

256-257. [note: cf. 6.1.26.c9] The south wind got its sand into my eyes: “Why do you strike me in the back?”

258-259. Between the basket and the boat are the fields of Simurrum.

260-261. You keep walking around the storehouse like a pig with a morsel in its mouth.

262. For him who is rejected by Inana, his dream is to forget.

263. Whether it is roasted or not, you should sprinkle the grain.

264-266. It is characteristic of your harvesting, it is characteristic of your gleaning, that they say: “He is gone, he is gone.”

267-271. [note: cf. 6.1.22: ll. 191-193, 6.1.28.27] “You should serve me” is typical of purification priests. Bowing over your hips is typical of leather-workers. To be stationed in all corners is typical of *lukur* women. “I will be there with you” is typical of gardeners. “I swear by Enki that your garments will take no time in this establishment” is typical of fullers.

272-275. [note: cf. 6.1.14.6, 6.1.16.c5, 6.1.22: ll. 172-175, 6.1.25.1] The day became cloudy but it did not rain. It rained, but not enough for people to undo their sandals. The Tigris was not surging at its inlet, so water did not fill the arable lands.

276-277. [note: cf. 3.3.07: ll. 5-7] In Eridug, built in abundance, the monkey sits with longing eyes in the singer's house.

278. Cream and milk are multiplied by an axe.

279. [note: cf. 6.1.15.f7] Let the solitary one remain alone; he is forever treacherous.

280. The goat spoke in the manner of a wise old woman but acted in the manner of an unclean woman.

281. [note: cf. 6.1.07.11, 1.8.2.1: l. 246] The clod on the one hand, the furrow on the other hand. And I am the third one there.

282. [note: cf. 6.1.07.15] Let me drink beer shandy and sit in the seat of honour!

283. [note: cf. 6.1.07.16] Although it was not important to him, he attended the festival.

284. [note: cf. 6.1.07.21] The time passed, and what did you gain?

285-286. [note: cf. 6.1.22: ll. 148-150] The figure is good. The father-in-law rejoices over it: “It is just like a real person!”

287. A good word is a friend to numerous men.

288. A destructive (?) word is four oxen yoked together.

289. Putting unwashed hands to one's mouth is disgusting.

290. May a clever farmer live at home with you.

291. My drink is a river. The place where I sleep is a place of reed mats.

292. The gecko wears a tiara.

293. [note: cf. 6.1.02.161, 6.1.25.8] “I'm going home” is what he prefers.

294-295. [note: cf. 6.1.07.79] The sun never leaves my heart, which surpasses a garden.

296. [note: cf. 6.1.04.4, 6.1.22: l. 189, 6.2.4: VAT 21604 (+) 21605 Seg. B l. 2] He holds up the sky, letting the earth dangle from his hands.

297. The *muš* barley is reserved for the necromancer.

298. Wheat flour is sacred to his god.

299-301. [note: cf. 6.1.25.13, 6.1.26.a10, 6.2.5: BM 57994 Seg. A ll. 1-3] If a man sailing downstream says “Give way!” (?) -- if the hand touches a woman's genitals over her clothes -- it is an abomination to Suen.

302-303. Carrying bread to the oven whilst singing is an abomination to Inana.

304. My ..... speaks deceitfully with my man.

305. The sheep (?) is shrouded in wickedness for him.

306. If the sieve is not shaken, his flour will not drop from it.

307. Coveting and reaching out for things [note: 1 ms. has instead:] spying are abominations to Ninurta.

308-309. I am confronting Fate: “Speak in the way of a just man, or speak in the way of a wicked man, it makes no difference.”

310. [note: cf. 6.2.2: MDP 27 89, 6.2.3: UET 6/2 322 l. 3] What comes out of one's mouth is not in one's hand.

311-312. *(2 lines fragmentary)* [note: 1 ms. has instead:] *(2 lines fragmentary)*

313-314. [note: cf. 6.1.07.77] He said: “Woe!” and the boat sank with him. He said: “Alas!” and the rudder broke.

315. [note: cf. 6.1.07.90] He is walking around despite his wounded neck.

316. [note: cf. 6.1.07.91] He turns things upside down.

317. [note: cf. 6.1.07.92] He devours things as crows do a field.

318. [note: cf. 6.1.07.105] A free weaver equals two slave girls [note: 1 ms. has instead:] one slave girl . A free worker equals three [note: 1 ms. has instead:] two slaves.

319. A spade is like a fisherman who does not make ..... fly (?).

320. [note: cf. 6.1.07.45] My mouth enables me to rival other men.

321-322. What is this after you split it? And this after you split it?

323-324. [note: cf. 6.1.07.99] When present, it was considered a loincloth; when lost, it is considered fine clothing.

325-326. [note: cf. 6.2.5: YBC 7347] If the leader is being devoured by a fire, those behind him don't say: “Where is the leader?”

327. To call out from among (?) the people.

328. When righteousness is cut off, injustice is increased.

Segment B

1-2. *(2 lines fragmentary)*

3-7. *(5 lines fragmentary)*

8. *(1 line fragmentary)*

Segment C

1-2. ..... not good ..... strong .....

3-4. ..... drinking water ..... *(1 line fragmentary)*

5. *(1 line fragmentary)*

Segment D

1-4. *(4 lines fragmentary)*